disappeared. It gives me a shiver even now to think about it.

I'd been shaky before that Leicester game, even though it was at Old Trafford, in the heart of the United family. The first away match of the season was the one everybody had been looking ahead to: West Ham at Upton Park. That was where people were expecting me to really feel the pressure. In a strange way, though, I found myself looking forward to it. I had this sense that I needed to experience how bad the abuse could be if I was going to get past it and put it behind me for the rest of the season. I knew it was going to be a challenge and I just wanted to get on with facing up to it.

I'll never forget arriving at Upton Park for the game. As I got off the team bus, trying to catch a glimpse of what was going on outside, there was this policeman standing at the door waiting for me. I thought he was standing on the steps at first. He was so huge he seemed to be blocking out the sun. It was almost as if the size of him was a warning about the scale of the hostility. They were waiting for me out in the parking lot: hundreds of people, anger all over their faces. It amazed me then. It amazes me even more, now that I'm a father myself: dads screaming at me, calling me every name under the sun, with their sons—six-or seven-year-olds—standing beside them, looking up at that kind of example.

It was only some time later, when I saw pictures of the crowd, that I perhaps appreciated how intense it was at Upton Park that day. I've got one particular photo at home that still spooks me: I'm taking a corner and you can see the expressions on people's faces in the crowd behind me. You can almost feel the aggression; it's caught there in the picture. And it's not: you're a crap player who cost us the World Cup and who should never play for England again. It's way past that, way past anything to do with soccer. The looks on those faces said it all:

'If we could, we'd have you, Beckham.'

That hatred makes you wonder what soccer's worth, if it provokes those sorts of emotions. If you snapped out of your concentration on the game and became aware of moments like that, what would you do? Walk off the field? I just don't understand it at all. Lucky for me, I felt whatever was coming my way I could take on the chin. When we came off at the end of the match, after a 0–0 draw, I felt a shudder of relief. I'd probably imagined far worse leading up to the day and it seemed the reality of it hadn't been that difficult to get through after all. The abuse from the fans, in the wake of France 98, didn't stop after that afternoon at West Ham; but it being a problem for me as a